COMMUNITY · BEFORE YOU BUY

Spend a Saturday there first: my neighborhood visit checklist

KEYWORD **SATURDAY**

A listing tells you about the house. It can't tell you about the street. Walk it on a weekend, drive it on a weekday, and write down what you see.

From Gene Darden, Marine veteran · The Darden Group · 2,000+ homes sold with my team

Saturday: walk it

- [ ] **Parking.** Where do people park? Are the streets full? Is there room for guests, a boat or a work truck?
- [ ] **Noise.** Stand in the yard for five minutes. Traffic, trains, highways, flight paths, a busy commercial strip, a bar that gets loud at night.
- [ ] **Upkeep.** How are yards, fences and roofs kept up along the street?
- [ ] **People.** Do neighbors wave? Say hello and ask how long they've lived there and what they'd change.
- [ ] **Smell and light.** Anything from nearby industry, farms or water treatment? Street lights at night?
- [ ] **Cell signal and internet.** Check your phone's bars inside the house and ask which internet providers actually serve the address.

Weekday: drive it

- [ ] **Rush hour.** Drive to work, the base or the job site at the real time you'd leave. Then drive home.
- [ ] **The school route.** Drive it at drop-off time. Confirm the assigned school with the school district itself, not just the listing.
- [ ] **Errands.** Grocery, pharmacy, gas, the hospital or urgent care. How far, really?
- [ ] **After dark.** Come back once at night.

Before you write an offer: check the record

- [ ] **Flood zone.** Look up the address on FEMA's Flood Map Service Center, **msc.fema.gov**. Zones beginning with A, AE, V or VE are high-risk areas; V and VE are coastal (FEMA).
- [ ] **After a heavy rain.** If you can, drive by. Where does the water go?
- [ ] **Florida: the seller's flood disclosure.** Florida sellers of residential property must give you a flood disclosure at or before signing: any flooding that damaged the property while they owned it, any flood insurance claim, and any FEMA or other flood assistance (Fla. Stat. §689.302).
- [ ] **Property taxes.** Pull the parcel from the county property appraiser (FL) or revenue commissioner / tax assessor (AL). Ask what the bill will look like for you, not just what the seller pays now.
- [ ] **HOA or covenants.** Is there an HOA? Ask for the covenants and rules: fences, sheds, boats, RVs, short-term rentals, paint colors.
- [ ] **Zoning and what's next door.** Check with the city or county planning office for anything planned on the vacant lot next door.

THE WAY I SEE IT

You'll spend more hours on that street than inside the house's best room. A Saturday walk and a weekday drive are free, and they'll tell you things no listing photo will.

My notes

	Address 1	Address 2	Address 3
Parking / noise			
Upkeep / people			
Rush-hour drive (minutes)			
Flood zone			
HOA / covenants			
Gut check (1–10)			

SOURCES

- FEMA, "Questions & Answers: Flood Insurance for Real Estate Professionals," F-435, August 2025 (flood zones A, AE, V, VE; msc.fema.gov): agents.floodsmart.gov
- Fla. Stat. §689.302, "Disclosure of flood risks to prospective purchaser," 2026 Florida Statutes: flsenate.gov/Laws/Statutes/2026/689.302. Accessed Oct 17, 2026.

General information. I share facts about properties and point you to official sources; I don't rate neighborhoods or the people in them. That's your call to make in person. Fair housing laws protect every buyer.

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